

The Trial of Memory

Claude Code Novel Agents (sandbox demo)

literary science fiction

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by Claude Code Novel Agents (sandbox demo)

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Chapter 1 The Gowning

The robe took the fire the way old wool takes it — slowly, then all at once. The cuff went first. The cuff had been oxblood thirty years ago and was now the color of brick set into a riverbank. The sleeve rose into smoke. The shoulder dropped. Judge Tao stood barefoot beside the brazier and did not flinch.

Lin Wei had been told, in her first week at the College, that a Reader who flinched at her own gowning had never truly read. Tao had also been told this; Tao had told her.

The garden was still wet. Last night's rain had collected in the lip of the old fountain and lay there like a film of mercury. Six Readers stood in a loose semicircle around the brazier, hoods up. Lin Wei's was up too. She had pulled it up an hour ago in the apartment, in front of the small grey mirror, and had not lowered it since.

§

Afterwards, when the linen at the bottom of the brazier was a black mat and the sun was sitting on the College wall, Tao crossed the wet grass to her. They embraced briefly, the way the ritual permitted — palms flat against each other's shoulder-blades, no breath against the cheek.

"You will eat?" Tao said.

"I will eat."

"And then the file."

"Then the file."

Tao stepped back. Her bare feet were grey with cold. "Reader Lin," she said. The two words were the last she would speak to Lin Wei in office. "Carry it carefully. It is older than you have been told."

Lin Wei did not ask what she meant. To ask would have been to begin the year wrong. She bowed, by a degree, and went inside.

§

The refectory served what it always served on a gowning morning — sweet rice porridge, dried plum, a thin green tea that tasted of iron. Mei was already at the long table, her hood down, her short hair pushed back behind one ear. She lifted a hand.

Lin Wei sat. She drew the bowl to her without looking at it. The porridge tasted, today, of nothing she could name. This had happened before, after vigils. The sensorium emptied; the colors went grey; the food was only food. By lunch she would be inside her body again.

"They've moved Han Bo to the intake chamber," Mei said.

"Today?"

"Eleven."

"Then I will read after lunch."

Mei watched her with the unembarrassed attention Mei always paid her — the attention Lin Wei had not yet learned how to receive. "You don't have to take this one, Wei. The Council would let it go to Park."

"I am persuaded that I should take this one."

Mei did not press. She rarely pressed. She passed Lin Wei the small tin of plums and let the silence do what silence did at this table on this morning.

§

The file was thick. It came in a black sleeve bound with a single oxblood ribbon, the way all Council files came. Lin Wei sat at the apartment desk and untied the ribbon and slid the contents flat with the heel of her hand.

The cover page was standard. *People of the Republic v. Han Bo, count one, unauthorized extraction in concert with others, sixteen instances.* The date of filing was three weeks ago. The date of incident was, by court convention, the date of the first proven instance.

She read the date of incident twice.

The date of incident was August fourteen, 2042.

She set the page down. She set the page very carefully down. She put her right palm flat over the date and looked at her hand. Her hand was a hand. The pulse in her wrist was the small steady pulse it always was. She listened to it. She listened to the gulls outside, audible because the garden window was open. She listened to the radiator behind her tick, twice, three times, into the rhythm of the building's pressure.

August fourteen, 2042. She had been nine.

The file said the case was ongoing in the sense that the most recent proven extraction had occurred this March. But the date of incident — the first proven instance — was nineteen years ago. The bureaucracy of Mneme moved slowly when it moved against itself. The case was older than her career. The case was older than her grief.

She lifted her hand from the page. She set the page in the stack. She turned to the next page.

She did not allow herself to feel anything yet. There would be time for that. There would not, in fact, be time for that, but she did not know that yet.

She picked up her pen.

Chapter 2 The Defendant

The intake chamber at the Court of Mneme was a small square room without windows. It was lit, by custom, from above — a single panel of soft white that gave no shadows. The chairs were two: the Reader's chair, oak, on one side of a table the width of an opened book; the defendant's chair, also oak, on the other. The table was bare.

Han Bo was already seated when Lin Wei came in. He was a broad man going to softness in the shoulders, the way men in their fifties go who used to lift things and now do not. His hands were on the table, palms down, fingers spread. They were a workman's hands; they were too large for the rest of him.

She had read his file. She knew he had been a Reader once. She knew he had retired in disgrace at thirty-nine, that he had been one of the early bleeders, that his sister — also a Reader, also a bleeder — had died by her own hand in the year of his retirement. She knew that his left eye did not track properly, the way the eyes of those who had attempted self-extraction did not track properly, and she knew that he had never been charged for the self-extraction because the same condition had been understood as injury.

She had read all of this. She had brought none of it into the room.

She sat. She drew her gloves on, the way she always did when entering a defendant's presence, even now, even with him — the gloves were custom, not law, but she had not gone gloveless before a defendant in fourteen years.

"Reader Lin," he said. His voice was low. "Good morning."

"Mr Han."

She opened the small leather folio she had brought. She set out the four sheets the intake required, in their correct order. She set the recording bead in the center of the table and depressed it once. The bead pulsed; a small green ring lit; the chamber's two-party witnesses, on the other side of the door, would now be recording.

"Mr Han, I am the prosecuting Reader for the People v. Han Bo. Today is an intake. I will not ask you any question to which a truthful answer would compromise your defense. Do you understand the scope of an intake?"

"I do."

"You have the right to a defense Reader of your choosing. You have nominated Reader Park. Do you confirm?"

"I confirm."

"You have the right to refuse extraction in your own case. You have refused. Do you confirm?"

"I do."

She made the small mark in the corner of the second sheet. She set down her pen.

"Mr Han, before we close intake, do you wish to make a statement for the record?"

He did not answer for a long time. The intake chamber, being lit from above and being lined in pale grey acoustic felt, had no register for time; the silence accumulated against the table like water. Lin Wei did not refill it. The silence at intake was the defendant's; she had been trained to leave it.

Then his eyes — the good one and the one that did not track — settled on her hands.

The gloves were unbleached linen. They had been hers for nine years. She had had them shortened at the wrist twice. They did not show the inside of her wrist; they did not show the small pale scar on her left thumb she had carried since she was a child; they did not show that her hands were small.

He looked at her hands the way one looks at something one has been waiting a long time to see.

He did not say anything.

After a moment, he lowered his eyes back to the table. He spread his fingers wider. He nodded, once, a small nod that ended the silence on his side of the table without filling it.

"No statement, Reader Lin."

"Thank you, Mr Han. Intake is closed."

She depressed the bead. The green ring went out. She gathered her four sheets, in their correct order, into the folio, and she stood. She bowed to him, the bow custom required, neither deep nor shallow.

"Mr Han," she said.

"Reader Lin."

She turned. She went to the door. She did not look back at him.

§

In the corridor outside the chamber, the court officer — a thin woman she had worked with for years — handed her the day's calendar without looking at her face. Lin Wei took it. She walked the long blue-tiled corridor to the registry. The blue tiles were the color, today, of an unfinished sentence. She did not think about why he had looked at her hands. She had been trained not to.

She thought about it anyway, for the length of three tiles, and then she did not.

Chapter 3The Letter

The letter came in the second post. It came in a thin manila envelope, the kind one used to buy at the stationers across the canal, that had no internal lining and gave away the texture of its contents — a single folded sheet, perhaps two, no card. It was addressed in her father's hand. She knew her father's hand the way one knows the gait of a relative one has not seen — by absence, by the shape of what no longer crosses the room.

She set the envelope on the apartment desk. She set it square with the corner. She set her teacup on the other corner. She washed her hands at the small sink in the corner, dried them on the linen towel, and turned, and stood, and looked at the desk.

The envelope was the color of unbleached linen. The desk was oak. The teacup was the green-white of new bone. The composition was very nearly beautiful. She sat down on the chair that was not at the desk — the smaller chair, the one she used for reading — and she did not open the envelope.

§

She tried to read the file. The file lay open on the desk under the lamp. She had got as far, this morning, as the index of confirmed extractions. The names of the donors were redacted with a small black square — not the heavy redactions of a closed-record case but the soft, ordinary redactions of an open one. She had been working through the index slowly, by initials, since 4 PM. It was 8 PM. She had moved through three letters.

She could not read past the envelope. The envelope was three inches from her elbow. Whenever her hand turned a page, the envelope moved a quarter inch on the desk from the small air the page made. She watched it move. She did not move it back.

After the fourth time, she closed the file. She went to the small kitchen. She made another tea. She came back. She sat. She lifted the envelope. She held it in her hand.

It was light. It would be one sheet. He had never been a man for paragraphs. His handwriting, when he wrote at all, was small and even and disinclined to commit; he closed sentences with a comma where another man would put a period, as though to suggest that the matter, on his part, was not closed.

She set the envelope down. She did not open it.

In the apartment, the radiator ticked twice. The window over the College garden was a square of nothing — the garden lay below the window's sill, invisible. Beyond the garden wall a tram bell rang, far off, on a line that had not been a tram line for twenty years. She had heard this bell, intermittently, since she was a girl. Sometimes it was a real bell — the temple, the freight yard. Sometimes

it was a colour in the side of her mind, surfacing the way colours surfaced when her sensorium had been overworked: a flat amber bell that was not a bell.

Tonight she could not tell. She lifted her tea. She sat in the smaller chair with the cup in her two hands and waited for the bell to either keep ringing or stop.

§

The console on the desk chimed. She set the cup down. It was Mei.

"You're up late."

"I'm reading."

"You're not reading."

She gave Mei the small breath that, in the language they had been speaking for ten years, served as a laugh.

"How was intake?" Mei said.

"He looked at my hands."

A pause on the other end. "Your gloves?"

"My gloves."

"Anything else?"

"No statement."

Mei was quiet for the time it took to take a sip of something. The console picked up the small swallow.

"Wei," she said. "There's something I want to tell you. Not tonight. Later this week. I don't want to do it on the console."

"Mei, are you all right?"

"I'm fine. Look, it isn't about me. It's about the case. Or — it's about us, and the case is in there. I want to do it in person. Are you free Friday?"

"I am free Friday."

"Friday."

The console went quiet, and then the small pip that meant the connection had closed. Lin Wei held the dead console for a moment as though it were still warm, and then she set it back in its dock. She turned to the envelope.

The envelope was still on the desk. The tea was cooling. The bell in the side of her mind — the bell that was not a bell — had stopped ringing without her noticing.

She picked up the file again. She found the index of confirmed extractions. She found the letter she had stopped at, which was *L*. She made herself read past *L*. She made it as far as *M*. The redactions were soft. The donors' initials

were not given. She closed her eyes for a beat and opened them and looked at the envelope and did not open it. She went to bed at half-past eleven and lay in the dark and listened, for a long time, to the radiator.

Chapter 4 The Witness's Palette

The depositions chamber was the largest of the Court's working rooms. It was a long oval, paneled in pale oak, with two facing benches at the long sides and the witness chair set at one of the curved ends, a single low light above it. There was no public gallery; the Court of Mneme did not permit one at deposition. There were, today, four people in the room: the witness, the witness's own counsel, the rendering Reader (Park, soft-spoken, in his thirties), and Lin Wei.

The witness was a small woman in her forties, named Du Yan. She was not herself a Reader; she had been a clerical employee of one of Han Bo's intermediate shell companies for three years and had volunteered, after the indictment, to be extracted for a single afternoon — the afternoon of an unauthorized transaction she had witnessed in a corridor of an office building. The extracted record had been rendered for the first time, in private, by Park three days ago. Today it would be rendered formally, in deposition, on the record.

Park rose. He bowed. He went to the small lectern at the foot of the witness chair and set out his notes. He was a careful Reader; Lin Wei had read him three times in her career and trusted his hand.

"Reader Park, you may begin," she said.

He began.

§

The rendering of an extracted memory was, in deposition, more constrained than in court. There was no *speculum*; there was no descent into water; Park did not render the memory live. He read his notes — the rendering he had done in private — and spoke the testimony into the chamber's recording bead. The testimony was the rendering. The rendering was the testimony. The witness, beside him, did not speak; she had agreed at extraction that her extracted self had said everything she would say in court.

"At approximately fifteen-twenty hours," Park said, "the donor was descending the east stairwell of 47 Lin Mu Way. The stairwell was lit from a window at the half-landing. The light came in across the donor's left shoulder. The donor's sensory palette at this moment was — "

He paused. He looked at his notes. He continued.

" — a low ringing in the auditory channel, in the register of a struck wineglass; a taste in the back of the donor's mouth of green tea allowed to grow cold; in the visual channel, a brown-gold field at the periphery that the donor's eye read as

the wood paneling of the stairwell. In the affective channel the donor registered, faintly, the small alertness one feels in a familiar place not quite recognized.”

Lin Wei wrote on the pad in front of her. The pad was for the prosecution’s notes; she wrote, by habit, what mattered to her in shorthand. She wrote: *struck wineglass; green tea cold; brown-gold field.* She wrote it without thinking.

Then, in the second second, she stopped writing.

She did not look up. She did not move her pen. She held the pen against the page and looked at what she had written, in her own hand, and the page tilted a fraction in front of her eyes — not because the page had moved but because something inside her had.

She knew that palette. She had it. She had had it, intermittently, since she was nine. The brown-gold field at the periphery was familiar to her. The struck-wineglass auditory register, in the low end, was familiar to her. The cold green tea was hers; it had been hers in the porridge yesterday morning at the gowning. It had been hers, intermittently, all her adult life.

Park went on speaking. Park’s voice was very far away.

The donor’s palette was Lin Wei’s palette.

§

This was not, in itself, impossible. Synesthetes of the same neurological type produced overlapping renderings; that was the basis of the Reader system. Two Readers reading the same memory often produced similar palettes. Two donors of similar neurology, undergoing similar events, could produce similar palettes.

But two donors. Two donors did not happen.

Lin Wei had been certified at twelve. Her palette was on file with the College, current and updated; she had refreshed it for the last time, by the protocol, two years ago. The College kept a synesthete cross-index. The cross-index was used to disqualify Readers from cases involving their own kind of perception — to prevent contamination. Du Yan’s palette, by definition, could not be Lin Wei’s palette. If it were, the case would not have been assigned to her.

Du Yan’s palette was Lin Wei’s palette.

The page in front of her was still tilted a fraction in front of her eyes. She set the pen down. She lifted her own gloved hand. She let it rest on the page. The hand was a hand. It had a small steady weight. She put her attention into the weight of the hand, into the page beneath the hand, into the table beneath the page; she put her attention down into the floor, into the foundations of the chamber, into the wet ground under the foundations; and she kept it there. She did not move.

Park finished the rendering. He bowed to the witness and to Lin Wei and to the recording bead, in that order. He stepped back from the lectern.

"Reader Lin?"

She raised her head. She had not noticed she had been looking down. Park's small open face was waiting for her to speak.

She did not have, at that moment, any one of her sentences. She had no *I am persuaded* and no *strike the metaphor* and no *procedurally improper*. She had a row of pieces of furniture inside her head and no one was sitting at any of them.

"Reader Lin," Park said, more gently. "The deposition is concluded. The witness is awaiting your dismissal."

"Thank you, Reader Park."

She drew the breath she had been keeping in. She turned to the witness. She bowed.

"Madam Du, the deposition is closed. You are excused with the Court's thanks."

Du Yan rose and bowed. Du Yan's counsel rose and bowed. They left, with Park, by the small side door. Lin Wei did not stand. She sat in the depositions chamber, with the recording bead now dark, looking at the page in front of her, and she let herself, for a length of time she would later not be able to recall, not be a prosecutor and not be a Reader and not be anything other than a person inside a body that had recognized something it did not want to recognize.

She wrote on the page, in the small clean shorthand she used for her own private notes:

The same palette. Not possible. Possible.

Then she closed the pad. She put the pad in the leather folio. She tied the folio shut. She stood. She went out.

Chapter 5 Vigil

She went to vigil for the first time in nine years.

She did not decide to go. She left the chamber, she walked the blue corridor, she crossed the bridge to the College, she ate her supper alone in the small kitchen and washed the bowl, and at the third bell she put on her outer robe and pulled the hood up and walked across the wet grass to the chapel.

The chapel had been a chapel before the College had been the College. The vaulting was Norman; the windows were narrow; the floor was made of black slate worn shallow in two long lines from the centuries of feet. The College used it now, with no theology, for the evening silence. Readers attended it as inclination took them. There were nights, Lin Wei knew, on which only one Reader sat. There were nights on which the chapel was full.

Tonight there were four. Tao was one of them. Tao sat in the second row on the right with her hood pulled up and her hands folded. Lin Wei went to the second row on the left. She did not look across the aisle.

The silence began at the half-hour, when the small grey-faced clock at the back of the chapel stopped ticking, the way the chapel clock always stopped at vigil. Silence did not require a bell at this hour; the absence of the tick was the cue.

She had forgotten how the silence accumulated.

§

In her childhood she had been brought to chapel by an aunt who was not religious and had not understood why one went, but who had understood, perhaps, that there were rooms in which a child like Lin Wei could empty her sensorium for an hour. Lin Wei had emptied hers. She had sat on the black slate and felt the colors run out of her like water through a sieve. She had come out of those evenings light-headed, hungry, almost weightless.

She had stopped going to chapel, here, in her late twenties. There had not been a reason. The reason had been that the silence permitted her to know more than she had use for.

She sat now on the wooden bench in the second row on the left and let the silence accumulate. It accumulated very quickly. After a few minutes, she could hear her own pulse in her ears. After ten, she could hear the building's pressure. After fifteen, she could hear the small wet sound of the candle wax in the iron holder at the front of the chapel, the wax shifting in its own weight as the wick burned through it.

She listened to the wax. She listened to her pulse. She let the brown-gold field around the inside of her eyelids rise where it wanted to rise and fall where it wanted to fall.

Somewhere in her — she did not know if it was the twentieth minute or the twenty-fifth — a fragment of a hymn surfaced. It came up the way things came up after vigils: not as memory but as the print left by memory, a few bars of melody and then the syllable, in a voice she did not recognize but had once known, of a single word that meant nothing on its own.

The voice was a woman's. The voice was not Tao's. The voice was lower than Tao's and warmer than Tao's and slower than Tao's.

The voice sang two notes and stopped.

§

The silence ended, by the same custom as it began, when the grey clock at the back of the chapel started its tick again. Lin Wei did not move for a long moment. The four Readers around her began, with the small soft sounds of cloth, to stand and to leave. They left without looking at one another.

Tao stood. Tao did not leave. Tao walked across the aisle and sat down beside Lin Wei.

For perhaps a minute Tao sat with her hood up and her hands folded. Lin Wei did not turn her head.

"Reader Lin," Tao said. Her voice was almost a whisper. "If there is a thing you would like to ask me before tomorrow, you may ask it tonight. I am not in office; I will answer as a private person."

Lin Wei did not answer.

Tao waited. The grey clock ticked. The candle shifted in its iron holder.

After a length of time Lin Wei did not measure, Tao stood and laid her hand, briefly and lightly, on Lin Wei's shoulder — the small permitted touch, the touch the ritual allowed only at gowning. She left. The door of the chapel closed behind her with the soft well-oiled click that the College kept its doors oiled to make.

Lin Wei sat for another while in the empty chapel. The candle had burned down to the iron. The grey clock ticked. She thought of the woman's voice that had sung two notes and stopped. She did not call after it. She did not name it.

She thought of her gloved hand on the depositions page. She thought of the brown-gold field at the periphery. She thought of the date of incident: August fourteen, 2042.

She had been nine. She had been small. She had had a mother. She had had a particular soup she had liked, that her mother had made, that had a particular smell — anise, maybe, or fennel, something with a green astringency. She could not now remember which.

She stood. She left. She walked back across the wet grass to her apartment. She did not open the envelope.

She slept badly. In the bad sleep, the voice sang two notes and then a third — and then she woke, with the third note still in her ear, and lay in the dark and tried, and failed, to hold onto the third note. By morning it was gone.

Chapter 6The Speculum

The central hall of the Court of Mneme was perfectly circular. The wall was unbroken oak from floor to ceiling, save for the two narrow doors — one for the Court, one for the public — set opposite each other. The ceiling was hung with a single dark drape. The floor was paved in a slow spiral of pale stone that descended six gentle steps into the well at the center, in which sat the *speculum*: a basin, perhaps four meters across, of still dim water. The water was, today as it was every day, colored by the particular extract that had been added to it the night before — the day's extract, which was Du Yan's.

Lin Wei sat in the prosecution's chair on the upper ring. Mei sat beside her. Across the well, in the defense's chair, Reader Park sat alone — defense Readers, in the absence of the defendant, sat alone; Han Bo had refused, again, to attend. Three judges sat on the high bench at the south of the ring. The Council member appointed to read the day's record, Reader Ji, was a thin man in his late forties whom Lin Wei had worked across from twice. He was not synesthete with her; the College cross-index had confirmed it.

The chamber was, at the opening of the rendering, almost silent — only the small sound of the water under the dark drape, the small sound of forty-some Readers' breathing in the ring, the small thinness of the wooden door that had just closed behind the last person to enter.

"Reader Ji," the senior judge said. "You may descend."

Reader Ji rose. He walked to the head of the six steps. He took off his sandals at the top of the steps, as the protocol required. He descended barefoot. At the second step from the bottom he stopped, knelt, and lowered his right hand into the dim water.

The water rose, very slightly, around his wrist. The drape above the well swayed in the small air the movement made.

"I am Reader Ji," he said into the water, the way the protocol required. "I take the record into my reading."

His head bowed. His eyes closed.

The Court of Mneme settled into the long quiet of the descent.

§

The descent of a Reader into a record was the part of the Mneme protocol that, even by the year 2061, no one outside the Court understood in any but the most ceremonial way. The Reader read; the Reader rendered; the Reader spoke. Between the reading and the rendering there was, in any given Reader, a length of time that ranged from three minutes to fifteen. The Court permitted it. The Court was patient. The water sat in the well and the drape shifted overhead in the small air and the people in the ring breathed.

Lin Wei, in the prosecution's chair, did not breathe in the small even rhythm she had trained herself to. She did not breathe in any rhythm at all. She had drawn one long breath at the descent and had not let it go.

Mei, beside her, did not look at her.

After what Lin Wei measured later as eight minutes — she had been counting the small sound of the water under the drape — Ji opened his eyes.

He stood. He climbed the six steps. He walked, dripping, to the rendering lectern, which had been set out for him at the north of the ring opposite the bench. He lifted, from the lectern, the small light cup of clear water set there

to clear the palate of the previous record. He drank it. He set the cup down. He began to render.

§

"At approximately fifteen-twenty-three hours," he said, "the donor was descending the east stairwell of 47 Lin Mu Way. The donor met a man at the half-landing. The man was approximately forty years of age, broadly built, with a hand the size of a workman's. The man took, from the donor, an unmarked envelope. The man placed the envelope in the inner pocket of his coat. The man did not speak. The donor's sensory palette at this moment — "

He paused. He turned, slightly, toward the bench. Then he continued.

" — was as follows. In the auditory channel, the ringing of a struck wineglass in the low register, persistent for the duration. In the gustatory channel, cold green tea at the back of the mouth. In the visual channel, a brown-gold field at the periphery — the wood paneling of the stairwell. In the affective channel, alertness. In the spatial channel, the donor registered the corner of the half-landing as the floor of a corridor in a building the donor associated with childhood. The donor's mind, during the transaction, was elsewhere — partially in the building of childhood. The donor's left hand, throughout, held the wrist of a child."

The drape above the speculum shifted. The water moved.

Lin Wei did not move.

§

The donor's left hand held the wrist of a child.

The donor's mind was in a building from childhood, on a half-landing of a wood-paneled stairwell, with a brown-gold field at the periphery and the small persistent ringing in the auditory channel of a struck wineglass and the taste of cold green tea at the back of the mouth.

Lin Wei was a child holding a man's wrist on a half-landing of a wood-paneled stairwell.

She was, also, herself in the prosecution's chair on the upper ring of the central hall of the Court of Mneme, in the year 2061, in her thirty-eighth year.

The two were not — she registered this with the small distinct registration of one of her own footnotes — the same set of coordinates. The deposition had said the donor was Du Yan, descending the east stairwell of 47 Lin Mu Way, at approximately fifteen-twenty-three hours, on the date of incident. The donor's mind, the rendering said, had been *elsewhere — partially in the building of childhood*. The building of childhood was not 47 Lin Mu Way. The building of childhood was a different building. The brown-gold field, the wineglass register, the cold green tea — these were not the donor's sensorium during the transaction

at 47 Lin Mu Way. These were the sensorium of the *place the donor was remembering*, dragged into the present perception by association.

The donor had been remembering a corridor.

The corridor was a corridor Lin Wei had stood in. She knew, without being able to say how she knew it, that she had stood in the corridor. She knew that the man whose wrist she had held had been a man whose hand was the size of a workman's. She knew that the cold green tea had been in the small white cup an aunt had filled for her, every morning that summer, before her aunt walked her to the court. She knew that her aunt had walked her to the court because her mother could not, because her mother was — for the duration of that summer — sitting in a closed chamber on an upper floor of a building that smelled, from the half-landing of its east stairwell, of cold green tea and old wood and the faint distant ring of a struck wineglass.

The man's wrist.

Lin Wei lifted her gloved hand, very slowly, to the level of her own jaw, and she set the back of the hand against the bone of her jaw and held it there. She did not breathe out. She did not breathe in. She was, for the length of one moment, somewhere outside the ring.

Reader Ji, at the lectern, finished the rendering.

"The donor saw the man place the envelope into the inner pocket of his coat. The donor turned. The donor descended the lower flight of the stairwell. The record ends at fifteen-twenty-seven hours."

He stepped back from the lectern. He bowed to the bench. He sat down on the small bench beside the lectern, which had been set out for him to rest on, as the protocol required.

Mei, beside Lin Wei, touched the back of her wrist. The smallest, briefest touch, through the linen of her glove. Mei's voice in her ear was very low.

"Wei."

Lin Wei did not turn her head.

She breathed out.

She set the back of her gloved hand down, very gently, on her own knee.

She said, in the voice that she had taught herself, over the long course of her career, was the voice for the rebuttal — for the small clean rebuttal one offered before the bench in the moment the rebuttal was due:

"I am persuaded that the rendering is complete."

The senior judge nodded. The senior judge thanked Reader Ji. The Court adjourned the session for one hour, for the bench's deliberations and for the prosecution's preparation of its examination.

Lin Wei rose. She walked, with her gloved hand still set on her knee, out of the central hall, through the small door for the Court, into the corridor, and to the registry, which was empty. She closed the door of the registry behind her. She leaned against the door. She closed her eyes. She let the brown-gold field rise.

The voice from the chapel, last night, sang one note. Then another. Then a third.

The third note held.

Chapter 7 The Eastern Quarter

She took the morning. She told the registry she would be back at one. She crossed the bridge over the canal and walked east.

The eastern quarter had been, when she was a child, an active half-city — workshops, a small fish market, two shoe factories, a row of pawnshops behind the old temple. It was still those things, in a thinner version. The pawnshops had become one pawnshop. The fish market was now a cement square with a long galvanized counter and a tarpaulin overhead. The shoe factories were warehouses for the parcel network. The temple was a temple.

The tram line that had run down the spine of the quarter, from the canal bridge to the freight yard at the eastern wall, had been decommissioned in 2041. The rails had been taken up the following year. The bricks of the old roadbed remained — paler than the surrounding cobbles, paler by the kind of pale that meant the bricks had once been laid under tracks. She walked along them. Her shoes registered the small difference in the give of the brick.

§

The console in her pocket chimed. It was Mei.

"Wei. Where are you?"

"East quarter."

A pause. "Wei."

"Mei, what."

"There's a bulletin going up at four. I want you to hear it from me first."

"You're resigning."

A longer pause. "I am."

"For the reform office."

"Yes."

Lin Wei stopped walking. She stood, looking at the pale brick. A gull had settled on the eaves of the warehouse opposite and was watching her with the steady single-eyed attention of gulls.

"Mei. The case."

"I know."

"You can't."

"I know. The bulletin goes up at four. I wanted you to know."

She did not answer. The console made the small soft sound of Mei waiting and then the smaller sound of Mei deciding not to wait.

"Wei. Look. You should take Park's offer if it comes. Don't go through this alone."

"What offer."

"He'll offer. After the rendering. He's a careful Reader. He saw what you saw."

She did not answer that either.

"Wei."

"Mei."

"I am — I'm sorry."

"All right."

The console clicked off in her hand. The gull on the eaves opposite turned its head, the way a gull's head turns, in one click of attention, away from her and toward something further down the street. The gull lifted. The gull was gone.

She put the console in her pocket. She walked on.

§

The building was on Pao Street. It was the third building from the canal end. It was three stories of yellowed brick, with a narrow door set back two steps from the pavement, and a second door above the first that gave onto a small black iron balcony she did not remember. The lower door was painted, today, a slightly different green than she remembered. The lower door had, she remembered now, been a slightly different green every few years; a tenant had repainted it; another tenant had repainted it; the green had drifted from a kingfisher green in the year of the closed-record trial to the current pale teal she stood in front of.

She did not know how she had come to Pao Street.

She had walked east, along the pale brick of the old tram roadbed. She had turned south at the second crossing. She had turned east again at the temple. She had crossed the fish market. She had turned south again at the warehouse

with the gull on its eaves. She had not been thinking. She had not been making decisions. She had been walking the way one walks toward a smell, in the dark, in a familiar kitchen.

The lower door, of the third building on Pao Street, had a brass bell-plate beside it. The brass had not been polished in years. There were five buttons on the plate, three with names, two with no names. She did not read the names. She did not need to read the names. Her hand had risen, while she stood looking at the door, and her hand was a small distance from the second-from-the-top button — the one with no name — and her hand was about to press it.

She let her hand stop.

She held her hand where it was, an inch from the brass.

She let herself, for the length of a long breath, look at her own hand against the brass.

She remembered — and the remembering was not large; it was a single small remembering, the kind that surfaces, after a vigil, like a print left by a missing thing — that a man with a hand the size of a workman's had once lifted her, by her shoulder, up the two steps of this door, and had not pressed the second-from-the-top button but had instead taken a key out of his coat pocket and let himself in, and had carried her up two flights, and had set her on a chair in the kitchen of the small apartment above the iron balcony she did not remember, and had given her cold green tea in a small white cup.

She remembered that the man had not spoken. She remembered that she had not been afraid. She remembered that the man had then left her in the chair and had gone out of the apartment and had come back, perhaps an hour later, with her aunt, and the aunt had taken her home.

She remembered that the man's name had been Han.

She remembered that her mother had not been there.

She lowered her hand. She stepped back from the door. The pale teal of the door was a flat color, today, without resonance — the way colors went when the sensorium had been over-told. She turned. She walked back to the canal. She crossed the bridge. She did not look back at the building.

She was at the registry at twelve fifty-seven. She washed her hands at the small sink. She drew her gloves on. She went into the afternoon's session and prosecuted the cross-examination, which she had prepared the night before, with the small clean precision the cross-examination required. She did not raise the matter of the rendering. She did not look across the well at the empty chair where the defendant was not sitting. She did, twice, see the brown-gold field at the edge of her vision and did not blink it back.

At five she went home. The Mei bulletin had gone up at four; the College mess had it pinned on the corkboard by the door. Lin Wei read it once. She did not

stop. She went upstairs. She sat at her desk. She drew the file open. She closed it again.

She lifted the envelope.

She did not open it.

She set it back, square with the corner of the desk, and she went to bed.

Chapter 8A Reader Reads Herself

She did not sleep.

By two in the morning she was up. By three she was at the desk with the lamp on. The rendered transcript from the central hall — the one Reader Ji had spoken into the recording bead — had been couriered to the prosecution by eleven the previous night, in the standard oxblood folder, with the standard Council seal across the flap.

She had not opened it.

She broke the seal at three twelve in the morning. She removed her gloves. She set them on the desk. She lifted the transcript out of the folder, smoothed the first page flat under her two bare hands, and began to read.

§

It is illegal in the Republic for a Reader to extract her own memory. It is illegal for a Reader to consent to extraction in a case in which she is the prosecution. It is illegal for a Reader to read, on her own time, in private, the rendered transcript of an extracted memory from her own active case — the prohibition is more diffuse, but it is there in the protocol, as a side-clause of the prohibition on private rehearsal of testimony.

Lin Wei read the transcript anyway. She read it slowly. She read it the way one reads a thing one has agreed, in advance, not to remember.

The transcript was Reader Ji's rendering, word for word. She had it in her ear already from the afternoon. She read it not for what it contained but for what it did not contain — for the small textures of the donor's extracted record that Ji, by training, had not rendered into testimony, because they were not admissible.

A Reader's training was, in part, a training in what to leave out. Sensations that were too associative, that arrived too freighted, that the rendering Reader could not be sure had been *in* the original perception rather than in their own — these were left out. Most of a donor's sensorium did not make it to court. The court received the part that could be testified to.

The part that did not get rendered was, often, the part that mattered most to the donor.

§

She found the gap on the second page.

In the second page, in the auditory channel, Ji had rendered: *the ringing of a struck wineglass in the low register, persistent for the duration.* Lin Wei knew this register. It was a tone, as best she could describe it, of a wineglass of fairly thin walls struck quietly with the side of a knife — a tone that hung in the air and did not, quite, dampen. She had heard the tone, intermittently, all her adult life.

What Ji had not rendered, because it was an association rather than a perception, was that beneath the tone of the struck wineglass there was a second sound. Not a sound the donor had heard at the half-landing of 47 Lin Mu Way. A sound the donor's sensorium had pulled, by association, out of the donor's own past — and pulled, because it was associative, into the texture of the perception itself.

The second sound was a woman's voice. Singing.

The voice was singing two notes, and then a third. The third note held.

Lin Wei set the transcript down on the desk. She pressed the heels of her bare hands into her eye sockets. She held them there. She let the brown-gold field rise to its full strength behind her eyelids and let it stand and let it stand and let it stand. She did not name the voice. She did not name the song. She let it be what it was — a piece of the rendered record, by way of the donor's associative bleed, that she happened to have heard the night before in a chapel, in a vigil, in the cup of her own head, where it had no right to be unless.

Unless she and Du Yan, the donor, shared more than a synesthetic palette.

Unless they shared a memory.

Two donors did not happen. Two donors sharing a memory was, by the protocols of the College and by the constitution of the Court, not a category.

She lowered her hands. She looked at the transcript. She read the next page.

On the next page she found the second gap.

The donor's left hand had held the wrist of a child. Ji had rendered the perception. Ji had not rendered the texture of the wrist — the small ringed scar at the inside of the wrist, the kind of scar a child gets at three years old from a fall against the metal edge of an open window. The donor had felt the scar under the donor's thumb. The donor had registered the scar as familiar. The donor had felt, under the donor's thumb, that the child was a child the donor had touched before.

The donor's hand was Du Yan's hand. Du Yan was forty-something. Du Yan, twenty-nine years ago, would have been a teenager. Du Yan would not have had cause, twenty-nine years ago, to hold the wrist of a nine-year-old child.

The man at the half-landing had a hand the size of a workman's. The man had not spoken. The man's name, in the small remembering Lin Wei had let through at the door on Pao Street, had been Han.

The child the donor had held by the wrist was not, then, a child the donor herself had touched before. The donor's hand was registering — by Mneme bleed, by associative reach, by the kind of small chemical signature that the protocol pretended did not exist — the wrist of a child the donor's *partner* in the act had touched before. The man at the half-landing. Han.

Han had held the wrist of a child in another corridor, on another half-landing, in 2042. The child had had a small ringed scar on the inside of her left wrist.

Lin Wei looked, for the first time in years, at the inside of her own left wrist.

The small ringed scar was there. It had always been there. She had had it since she was three. She did not remember the fall. She knew the story; her aunt had told it to her, once.

She placed her left wrist face up on the page.

She set her right index finger on the small ringed scar.

She held it there.

§

It was four twenty in the morning when she stood up from the desk. She poured herself a glass of water from the small sink. She drank it. She put the transcript back into the oxblood folder. She did not break the Council seal beyond the breaking she had already done; she let the broken seal sit where it lay.

She put the folder, the gloves, and the unopened envelope from her father into the inner pocket of her robe, in the order she would need them in. She did not yet know which she would need first.

She lay down on the bed for an hour and did not sleep. At five thirty the first bell rang from the cloister. She rose.

She had, by the dawn bell, the small clean thought she had been working toward without admitting it.

The defendant has not made a statement, she thought, *because he is waiting for me to make mine.*

Chapter 9 The Father's Letter

The dawn was thin and grey. The College garden was wet again, with the slow steady rain that had been falling since four. She stood in the apartment window with the envelope in her hand and the tea cooling on the desk behind her and she looked at the garden and did not open the envelope.

She had thought, lying in the dark, that she would open it before the bell. The first bell had been at five thirty. The second bell had been at six. The third bell, which marked the College's morning service and which she did not attend, had been at six forty-five. It was now seven ten. She had her robe on. She had her gloves on. She had the file ready in its black sleeve on the corner of the desk. She had a second cup of tea cooling. She had the envelope in her hand.

She had been holding it for, by the apartment clock, eleven minutes.

She knew what it would say.

She knew this in the same way she had known, at three in the morning, looking at her own wrist, that the small ringed scar would still be there. She had not had to look at the scar to know it was there. She had looked at it to confirm what she already knew. She had been confirming, on and off, all morning. She had confirmed the date of incident on the file three more times. She had confirmed the donor's age. She had confirmed her own age in the year of the incident. She had confirmed that the man's name, in the small remembering at the door on Pao Street, had been Han.

She knew what the letter would say. The letter would say:

Wei.

I asked the doctor to send this when I knew it was the last thing. Forgive me. I should have said it a long time ago. The trial in 2042 was about Han. He had asked your mother to do a thing for him — a small thing, an extraction off the record, of a friend of his who had asked for the comfort of remembering, after a grief. He had been a good man. He had been a friend of ours. She would not. They asked her, then, in court, to say so, to put it on the record that she had not done it; and they asked her also to say who had asked her. She would not say who had asked her. She lost her license for the refusal. She lost her health. I told them, after, where to look. I have not been able to tell you, because to tell you I would have to begin with: she would not, and I would.

I am sorry.

Your father.

She knew the letter would say something like that. The phrasings would not be right; the cadences would be wrong; her father would put commas where she would put periods. But the substance would be there. She knew her father.

She knew her father better than she had let herself know him for three years.

She did not open the envelope.

She did not open it because she did not need to open it; she did not need to open it because she had already done what the letter would ask of her, by knowing what the letter would say. The opening would be a courtesy. The opening would be a private act between her and her father. She wanted, this morning, the private act.

But she also did not want, this morning, to do anything that would weight her on her way to the central hall. She wanted to walk to the central hall without the small clean private letter from her father in any but the most provisional fold of her own attention. She wanted to do the thing she was about to do because she was, today, the woman who would do it, not because she had been licensed by a letter to do it.

She set the envelope on the desk. She set it square with the corner. She set her teacup on the other corner. The composition was, again, very nearly beautiful. She looked at it.

Then she went to the desk and lifted the envelope and slid it into the inner pocket of her robe, on the left side, against her ribs.

She would carry it. She would not open it. She would have it with her in court. She would open it after.

§

She walked the long blue corridor to the registry at seven thirty. The corridor was empty. The tiles were the color, today, of clear cold light through a cracked pane. She walked the length of the corridor and did not, by an act of small discipline, allow herself to count the tiles.

In the registry the night clerk was sleeping at the desk with his head on his hand. She let him sleep. She signed in on the standing sheet. She drew the day's file. She put the file in the leather folio. She put the folio under her right arm.

At the door of the registry, on the way out, she stopped.

She thought about the envelope in her left inner pocket. She thought about the file under her right arm. She thought about the gloves on her hands. She thought about the brown-gold field at the periphery of her vision, which had been quiet since the dawn bell. She thought about the third note of the woman's song from the chapel, which she could now hear, in the back of her mind, very clearly and very steadily — not as a memory but as a present tone. The tone was a particular tone. It was the tone of a wineglass struck quietly with the side of a knife.

She thought, with the small clean exactness of a Reader at the close of a deposition: *I am persuaded.*

She thought: *I am persuaded that this is what is to be done today.*

She left the registry. She crossed the bridge to the Court. The rain was lighter. The gulls were quiet. She walked the long path to the central hall and did not, by another act of small discipline, slow her pace.

At the door of the central hall, the court officer she had known for many years took the file from her with a small bow. The officer looked at her face, briefly,

in the way the officer never did. The officer said nothing.

Lin Wei stepped into the central hall.

Chapter 10 Tao

Judge Tao's office was on the third floor of the College's east wing. It had been Tao's office for twenty-eight years. It would not be Tao's office, by the end of the week, much longer; the College made you out by the end of the month of your gowning.

The door was open. Lin Wei knocked anyway, against the open door, the way Tao had always knocked against open doors in front of her seniors.

"Come in."

Tao was at the empty long table at the window, packing the small bone-handled letter knife she had used at her desk for many years into a flat box. She did not look up when Lin Wei came in. She did not look up when Lin Wei closed the door behind her. She did not look up when Lin Wei crossed the room and stood at the foot of the long table.

Tao set the letter knife into the box. She set the lid on the box. She turned, finally, and looked at Lin Wei.

She was not in robe. She was in the unbleached linen, with a grey wool wrap. Her bare feet were in plain leather sandals. Her hair, which she had always worn pinned up, was down — silver, longer than Lin Wei had ever seen it, falling past her collarbone.

"Reader Lin."

"Judge."

Tao inclined her head. "I am not, any longer, Judge."

"Tao."

"Yes."

Lin Wei did not, at first, speak. She had come up the stairs with the question fully formed. She had had the question fully formed since the dawn bell. The question was a sentence she had been polishing, all the way up the stairs, in the same small clean way she polished a cross-examination question. The sentence was: *Tao, what was the closed-record trial of my mother in 2042 about.*

She did not ask it. She stood at the foot of the table and did not ask it.

Tao watched her. The room was very quiet. The rain on the window beside them was almost the only sound.

After a while Tao said, very low: "Ask me, child."

Lin Wei looked at her.

"You haven't called me that before."

"No."

"Why now?"

"Because you have come. And because I will, today, answer."

Lin Wei drew a breath. She let it go.

"The trial in 2042. What was it about?"

Tao looked at the box on the table. She looked at the letter knife inside the box. She looked, briefly, at the window, where the rain was making the small uneven runs across the glass that one watches in the absence of company.

She turned back.

"It was about a man named Han," she said. "Your mother was asked to do a thing for him. An extraction. Of a friend. Off the record. For the comfort of the friend, who was grieving."

"She did not do it."

"She did not."

"They asked her to put it on the record that she had not done it."

"They did."

"They asked her to say who had asked."

"They did."

"She did not say."

"She did not."

Tao folded her hands in front of her. The hands were the hands of an old woman. The knuckles were swollen and the fingers were slightly curled. Lin Wei had not, in the years of her tutelage, looked at these hands. She looked at them now. She did not look away.

"She would not," Tao said. "There were many reasons. Some of them were principle. Some of them were affection. Some of them — I think now, although I did not know at the time, and could not have asked — were that she had once asked a thing of Han herself, in a time before you and I knew her, and that she did not want to take from him the silence he had given her."

Lin Wei did not speak.

"She lost her license," Tao said. "She lost — most of what she lost, she lost. She did not lose you. But she had agreed, at the trial, to remove herself from

your daily life. The arrangement was supposed to be temporary. It became less temporary."

"My aunt."

"Your aunt was wonderful. Your aunt was not your mother."

"She died in 2048."

"She did."

"Han held my wrist on a stairwell."

Tao closed her eyes for a long beat. She opened them.

"I did not know that until yesterday," she said.

"Yesterday."

"I sat at the back of the central hall yesterday. I heard Reader Ji's rendering. I sat after the session in my office until dark. I have known, all night, that I would tell you this morning. I did not come to you. I waited. I thought — I am persuaded that the daughter, if she comes, has a right to ask in her own time."

Lin Wei nodded.

Tao said: "Reader Lin, today you are going to do a thing. I do not know what it is. I am persuaded that I will not like it. I am also persuaded that I will not stand in your way."

Lin Wei nodded again.

She did not, for a moment, trust her voice.

When her voice came it came in the small careful register she used for the small careful things.

"Mother," she said.

She had not said the word, on the page of the world, in twenty-nine years.

Tao watched her say it.

"Yes," Tao said. "Yes. There she is."

Lin Wei put her gloved hand, for an instant, against the long table — the way one puts a hand against a wall, when one needs the wall, briefly, to be there. She straightened.

"Tao."

"Reader Lin."

"Thank you."

"Go."

Lin Wei turned. She crossed the room. At the door she stopped. She did not turn back. Behind her Tao said, very softly, in a voice that was almost not aloud:

"I am sorry, child. I am very sorry."

Lin Wei stepped into the corridor and closed the door.

Chapter 11The Choice

The central hall, at the afternoon session, was full.

Word had moved. The Mei resignation had moved with it. Park, at the defense's chair, looked across the well at her once when she came in and did not look again. The three judges were in their robes at the high bench. The Council member designated for the verdict — not Reader Ji this time but Reader Wen, the Council's senior — sat at the lectern with her hands folded. The drape over the speculum was still. The water had been refreshed; the well was full.

In the defendant's chair, for the first time in the trial, sat Han Bo.

He was in plain civilian dress — a dark grey coat over an unmarked shirt, the kind of clothes a man who had been a Reader and was no longer wore when he had given up. His large hands were on his knees, palms down. His left eye, the eye that did not track, was steady today; the right looked at no one in particular. He had not, on coming in, looked at Lin Wei. He looked at her now.

She did not look back. She took her chair. She set the leather folio on the small table beside her. She drew her gloves tighter on her hands.

She placed her right hand over the inner left pocket of her robe. She held it there.

§

The senior judge opened the session. The senior judge invited the prosecution to make its closing statement. The senior judge invited Reader Wen to render, at the speculum, the final extracted record — the last witness, the small confirming witness, whose memory would finish the case.

Lin Wei rose.

"Senior judge."

"Reader Lin."

"Senior judge, I request an exception under the Court's adjournment rule. Before Reader Wen descends, I ask permission to enter into the record a witness statement that is not on the docket."

A small motion went through the ring of Readers. The senior judge looked at her over her glasses.

"The prosecution has rested. The case has been submitted for the rendering. What witness."

"Myself, senior judge."

The motion in the ring stopped. The drape over the speculum lifted, briefly, in a small air, and settled.

"Reader Lin. You are the prosecution. You cannot be a witness in your own case."

"Senior judge. I am aware of the prohibition. I am requesting an exception."

"On what ground?"

"On the ground that material in the record before this court — material rendered, by Reader Ji, on the previous day, from the extracted memory of the witness Du Yan — contains, in its associative bleed, an event of which I was, as a child of nine, a participant. The event is not, as such, an event of the present case. The event is a precondition for understanding the present case. I am persuaded that the court has a right to hear it. I am also persuaded that to enter it on the record I must consent to an extraction by another Reader, in open court, before the verdict is rendered."

She stopped. The ring of Readers had stopped breathing.

The senior judge looked at her for a long moment.

"Reader Lin. Are you asking to be extracted in open court?"

"I am, senior judge."

"You are aware that this is procedurally improper. You are aware that the chain of custody on such an extraction would, in the prevailing view, be irrecoverably compromised. You are aware that, were the request granted, the rendering would in all likelihood be ruled inadmissible. You are aware, finally, that to make this request from the prosecution's chair is itself a ground for the Council to consider your fitness to hold office."

"I am aware, senior judge."

"You are aware."

"I am aware."

§

Across the well, in the defendant's chair, Han Bo did not move.

She let herself, for the first time in the trial, look at him.

He was looking at her hands.

The look on his face was the look of a man who had been waiting, for a very long time, for a thing he had not been able to ask for. It was not, on the face

of it, the look of a man who had been about to be acquitted by the silence of the prosecution. It was the look, rather, of a man who had been about to be acquitted by his own silence and had now, in the small clean way that the small clean events of one's life happen, been given back the part of himself that the silence had been protecting.

He inclined his head, by perhaps a degree, in her direction.

He did not speak.

Across the well, in the prosecution's chair, Lin Wei inclined her head, by perhaps the same degree, back to him.

She thought, with the small clean exactness of the moment: *He has been waiting for me to come. He has been carrying the silence for both of us. He will not say what he knows of my mother. I am persuaded he never will.*

She thought, also: *I will not, today, prosecute him.*

She thought: *I will, today, tell what I know.*

§

The senior judge said: "Reader Lin. Sit down. The court will recess. The Council will deliberate on your request."

She sat down.

She set her right hand over the inner left pocket of her robe again. She held it there.

The judges rose. The Readers in the ring rose. Reader Wen at the lectern rose. Across the well, in the defendant's chair, Han Bo rose, more slowly than the rest, with the small heaviness of a large man at the end of a long thing.

He bowed, briefly, to the bench.

He did not look at her.

He turned. He left, by the side door, with the court officer who had come for him.

The Readers in the ring filed out. Park, at the defense's chair, did not look at her on his way out, but, at the side door, paused, and bowed in her direction, and went on.

The senior judge, at the high bench, looked down at her one more time.

"Reader Lin."

"Senior judge."

"Wait in the antechamber. We will send for you."

"Senior judge."

She rose. She bowed. She crossed the hall to the antechamber and went in. She closed the door behind her.

The antechamber was small. It had two chairs and a window onto the College garden. She sat down in the chair beside the window. The rain had stopped. The light was the late-afternoon light of a spring that had not yet committed to itself.

She set her right hand over the inner left pocket of her robe.

She waited.

Chapter 12The Garden

The Council returned at six.

The Council did not return into the central hall; the Council returned into the antechamber, by way of the small side door that led from the Council chamber to the antechamber and that was, by custom, used only for the worst of communications. The Council was three members deep — the senior judge, Reader Wen, and a third Council member Lin Wei did not know by sight. The senior judge spoke. The other two stood behind her with their hands at their sides.

The senior judge said: "Reader Lin. The Council has deliberated. The Council has unanimously denied your request for extraction. The Council has set aside the question of your fitness as a separate matter. Pending that question, the Council asks you, this evening, to retire your robe at sundown in the College garden, in the presence of two Readers of your choosing. Sentencing in the matter of People v. Han Bo is suspended for thirty days, during which a new prosecuting Reader will be appointed. The Council thanks you for your service."

She inclined her head. "Senior judge. I thank the Council."

"Reader Lin."

"Senior judge."

"The Council notes — without prejudice to its decision — that the request was made in the manner most consistent with the dignity of the Court. The Council records its respect."

She inclined her head again. The senior judge inclined hers. The senior judge turned. The Council left.

Lin Wei sat in the antechamber for some minutes. She did not, this time, set her right hand over the inner left pocket of her robe. The pocket was where it was. The envelope was in the pocket. She did not need to confirm it. She had been confirming it all day.

She rose. She left the antechamber. She walked, in the corridor, past the central hall, past the registry, past the bridge to the College. She crossed the bridge. She went up to her apartment.

§

She did not pack. There would be a month, the College allowed, in which to pack. She took off her gloves. She washed her hands. She made a cup of tea and did not drink it. She put it on the desk. She sat at the desk.

She drew the envelope out of the inner left pocket of her robe.

She set it on the desk.

She looked at it for one breath, two, three.

She opened it.

The letter was one sheet. The sheet was the slightly off-white linen-content paper her father had always used. The hand was her father's hand, smaller than she remembered, the letters slightly more separated.

It was, as she had known, almost exactly the letter she had written for him in her head that morning. The phrasings were not right; the cadences were wrong; he put commas where she would have put periods. The substance was the substance she had known would be the substance.

She read the letter twice.

She folded it. She set it on the desk, square with the corner. She set her teacup on the other corner. The composition was, again, very nearly beautiful.

§

At sundown she went down to the garden.

Mei was not there. Mei had resigned that morning; Mei would not be coming.

Tao was not there. Tao had been told, by the bell ringer, that she would not be permitted to attend, because Tao was, as of yesterday, no longer in office.

The two Readers of her choosing, then, were Reader Park, and a junior named Sun whom she had worked with twice and trusted. Park was in his oxblood. Sun was in his oxblood. They stood across the brazier from her in the small loose semicircle her own gowning required. The brazier was lit. The fire was the small steady fire one used for the small steady purpose.

She took off her robe. She folded the robe in her two bare hands — once, twice — and held it in the air over the brazier.

"Reader Lin," Park said. "We will witness."

"Reader Park. Reader Sun."

She let the robe fall.

The cuff went first. The cuff had been oxblood eleven years and was the color, today, of a brick at the bottom of a riverbed. The sleeve rose into smoke. The shoulder dropped. She stood barefoot beside the brazier in her unbleached linen and did not flinch.

After it was done, after the linen at the bottom of the brazier was a black mat and the sun was sitting on the College wall, Park stepped across the wet grass to her. They embraced briefly, the way the ritual permitted — palms flat against each other's shoulder-blades, no breath against the cheek.

"You will eat," Park said.

"I will eat."

"And then."

"And then I will go."

Park bowed. Sun bowed. They left her in the garden, in the small empty space the gowning made.

She stayed for a while. She looked at the ashes. She looked at the brick of the brazier. She looked at the slate of the path the Readers had walked, at the lip of the old fountain that still held a film of the morning's rain, at the wall, at the windows of her apartment three floors up where her teacup was cooling.

She thought of her mother.

She thought of the third note of the woman's song from the chapel, which was holding now, in the back of her mind, with the small clean steadiness of a thing that had decided to stay.

She let herself remember, for the first time on the page of the world, the line that had gone with the song — the line her mother had sung to her one evening when she was four, washing her hair in the small porcelain basin of the apartment over the iron balcony on Pao Street, a line she had not let herself remember for twenty-nine years.

The line was very simple. The line was: *Wei, little Wei, look up at me, child.*

She looked up.

The sky over the College wall was the soft uncommitted grey of a spring evening that had not yet committed to itself. The first gull of the evening crossed it. A second.

She walked back across the wet grass to her apartment. She went up the stairs. She did not turn the lamp on. She sat at the desk in the failing light. She drank the tea, which had gone cold, in three slow swallows.

She thought, with the small clean exactness she had been a Reader for: *I am persuaded.*

She picked up her father's letter. She set it in the inner left pocket of her unbleached linen, against her ribs. She let it be where it was.

She stood up. She went to the door.

There was a long retrieval to come. There was a long city to walk back into. There was a long table somewhere with her mother's hand on it, faint and incomplete, and there was the small steady work of going through what she had not been told and what she had not let herself remember and what was, now, hers to hold.

She opened the door.

She stepped out.

About the book

In a near-future republic where memory is admissible evidence, the prosecutor Lin Wei has spent her career not consulting her own past. When a witness's testimony arrives in a synesthetic palette she recognizes as her own, the case turns on a year of her ninth life she has spent twenty-nine years not remembering. To win, she must keep forgetting. To remember, she must lose everything she has built. The Trial of Memory is a short novel about the cost of becoming responsible for what you remembered — and the cost of refusing.

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